

5 Whys

Iterative questioning to reach a root cause

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

5 Whys is a root-cause technique in which you ask 'why?' repeatedly — conventionally about five times — each answer forming the basis of the next question, until you move past symptoms to an underlying, addressable cause. The number five is a rule of thumb, not a law.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Developed within the Toyota Production System by industrialist and engineer Taiichi Ohno as a core problem-solving discipline.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams routinely fix symptoms and see problems recur. Ohno wanted a fast, cheap way to keep probing until the true cause — often a process or system flaw — was exposed.

HOW IT IS USED

State the problem, ask why it happened, answer, then ask why of that answer, iterating until a root cause emerges that, if fixed, prevents recurrence. Answers should be evidence-based, not guesses.

WHEN IT IS USED

Problem clarification and quality/operations troubleshooting; also as a framing tool before ideation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Operations and quality teams, product managers, and anyone diagnosing a recurring failure.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It converts vague blame into a **traceable causal chain** using nothing but disciplined questioning — the simplest of Toyota's lean problem tools, and a gateway to deeper framing methods.

FIGURE 1 · DRILLING TO THE ROOT

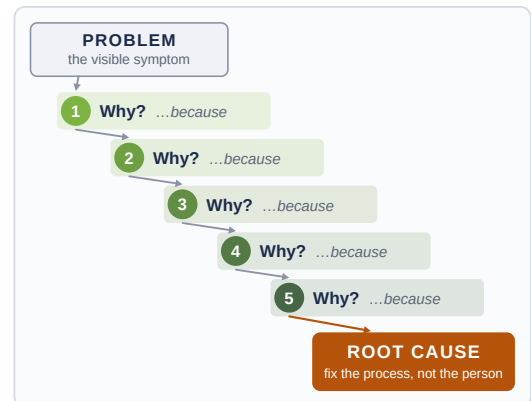


Figure 1. Each answer becomes the next question until a correctable root cause — not a symptom — is reached.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Reframing Matrix *Slibrary 4*

Critical Items Diagram *Slibrary 6*

How Might We (HMW) *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Ohno, T. (1988) *Toyota Production System: Beyond Large-Scale Production*. Portland, OR: Productivity Press.

Serrat, O. (2017) 'The Five Whys Technique', in *Knowledge Solutions*. Singapore: Springer.